traces of Shansabani presence, the more nomadic traces not being easily recoverable. On the other hand, the Bamiyan Shansabanis' architectural patronage seemed to be focused largely on repurposing pre-existing structures and complexes. This was evidently the case at the numerous fortifications and citadels to the west of Bamiyan, including Shahr-i Zuhak. Furthermore, at Shahr-i Ghulghula Ghaznavid-period structures were apparently put to Shansabani use. Although new construction in the Bamiyan region occurred less frequently, the newly built palatial complex at Sarkhushak nonetheless indicated a court life and ceremonial gradually diverging from that of their Firuzkuh cousins.

The differences between the earlier commissions discussed in Chapter 3, and the monumental foundations at later Firuzkuh and its ambit, as well as the interventions at Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar (Chapter 5), are even more significant. Thus, the juxtaposition of *all* of these architectural corpora – such as they are known from their surviving traces – makes it clear that any singular, overarching characterization such as "Shansabani/Ghurid architecture" would be untenable.

Here, it is important to note that what might appear to be a largely silent, background process must in fact be foregrounded in the study of an empire emerging from transhumance and/or nomadism and consisting of various lineages: given the particularly complex and often piecemeal process of Islamization among nomadic and many other non-elite groups (cf. Chapter 2), it is necessary to re-examine the scholarly assumption that, in general, patrons determined the ultimate outcomes of their projects. Actually, how much interest did the historically and even persistently transhumant Shansabani elites of Firuzkuh and Ghazna – though the latter increasingly engaged with already existing palace architecture (see Chapter 5) – have in determining the architectural forms and epigraphic programs of the buildings they commissioned? What did it fundamentally *mean* for nomadic, seasonally transhumant, or gradually sedentizing elites to patronize monumental architecture? Addressing these questions helps to shed light on the nature, inner workings, accumulation, and exercise of power by the Firuzkuh Shansabanis. In the context of historically transhumant/nomadic elites crafting a loosely intertwined imperium – and one spanning multiple cultural geographies – we must revisit the role and input of the patron in the design of buildings and their inscriptions, as well as the reception of the structures and their epigraphic programs by the many groups using and maintaining them.

By means of close examination, the Firuzkuh Shansabanis' large-scale architectural projects elucidate the encounter between *more* nomadic and sedentizing elites and the Perso-Islamic cultural complex. The latter encompassed – but was not limited to – Persianate literary and other cultural productions as well as what might be termed for convenience the "Great Tradition" of Islamic orthodoxies (cf. Chapter 1). The internal